In the nonexistent mind...

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"In the non-existent mind, nonexistent representations arise without a shadow of contradiction..." ***Chandrakirti***

The aim of this study is to examine the characteristics of such a **"non-existent mind"** as well as the representations that arise within it, and to attempt to justify the impossibility of the emergence of the representation of **"true absence"** in the mind.

1. Nominal Existence of Representations

In the **"non-existent mind,"** the existence of representations is ***nominal*** (conditional):

- The representation of **"affirmation"** (nominal existence) — for example, **"Being."**
- The representation of **"negation"** (absence of nominal existence) — a negation based on its representation of **"affirmation,"** such as **"non-Being."**
- The representation of **"double negation"** (absence of nominal non-existence) — the negation of the object of negation, for example, **"there is no non-Being."**

The **"non-existent mind,"** once designated (endowed with conditional existence), can designate (endow with conditional existence) both **"Being"** and its **"non-Being."**

However, the **"non-existent mind"** is incapable of designating **"non-existent non-Being."** For this, the mind would need a ***"non-existent representation"*** through which it could optimally designate **"non-existent non-Being."**

2. Double Negation

Representations of **"true absence"** (double negation) can be recognized by the mind in two ways:

FALSELY

In the representation of **"there is no non-Being"**: which arises in the mind, **"non-Being"** is granted nominal existence, which is then negated. Since **"there is no non-Being"** is the object of ***double negation***, it cannot have a representation in the mind, as it lacks a foundation (an object of affirmation). Therefore, it endows **"non-Being"** with

nominal existence (a pseudo-representation of **"affirmation"**) upon which it depends to negate it.

> Such a mind is obscured by primordial ***"natural ignorance,"*** from which two roots arise: belief in the inherent existence of **"external phenomena"** and the inherent existence of the **"self."**

3. The Impossibility of Representing True Absence

These two roots support the arising of ***saṃsāra*** (the completeness of conditioned phenomena) when all the links in the chain of dependent origination are formed. The living being experiences ***"compulsory birth"*** and the suffering associated with it. However, since this condition is ***impermanent***, it can also be brought to an end.

4. The Arising of Duality

The **"non-existent mind,"** obscured by ***"natural ignorance,"*** attributes nominal (conditional) existence to **"non-existent non-Being."** From this, the twelve links of dependent origination unfold.

5. The Twelve Links of Dependent Origination

1. **Ignorance** (***avijjā***) — the mind, obscured by natural ignorance, attributes nominal existence to "non-existent non-Being."
2. **Formative Factors** (***saṅkhārā***) — from this arises the nominal existence of "Being."
3. **Consciousness** (***viññāṇa***) — which in this case does not serve as a foundation but rather depends on the nominal existence of "non-Being." Consequently, the dual concepts of "self" and "non-self" emerge.
4. **Name and Form** (***nāmarūpa***) — both of which, in an obscured mind, possess inherent (self-existent) reality due to the fundamental obscuration of natural ignorance.
5. **The Six Spheres of Perception** (***saḷāyatana***) — such as "being and non-being," "false and true," "cold and hot," "love and hatred." All of these perceptions are tainted by fundamental ignorance — the belief in their own self-existent, independent reality.
6. **Contact** (***phassa***)
7. **Feeling** (***vedanā***) — this leads to the sprouting of the "seed of saṃsāra."
8. **Craving** (***taṇhā***) — craving for existence, which gives rise to actions of body, speech, and mind.
9. **Clinging** (***upādāna***) — these actions generate both wholesome and unwholesome kamma.

10. **Becoming** (***bhava***) — which in turn casts the "living being" into the cycle of conditioned existence.

11. **Birth** (***jāti***) — this state is conceptual-phenomenal pseudo-existence, based on the dependent origination of mutually exclusive representations (the most fundamental of which are "self" and "non-self").

12. **Old Age and Death** (***jarāmaraṇa***) — trapped in this cycle, the being is forced to suffer for countless eons in the darkness of ignorance, and the cycle repeats.

6. The Key Role of Craving

In practical terms, the key link is ***taṇhā*** (craving), which arises on the basis of ***vedanā*** (feeling). It is precisely at this link that the further unfolding of the chain can be ***ceased***.

> *If craving does not arise, clinging does not arise.*
> *If clinging is absent, becoming does not arise.*
> *If becoming is absent, birth does not arise.*

Thus, the cessation of suffering is connected with the ***cessation of craving***, not with the construction of new conceptual frameworks.

7. Cessation of Craving and the End of Suffering

The breaking of the chain of dependent origination is ***not*** achieved through conceptual understanding of the absence of inherent existence of phenomena alone.

Even if the mind is capable of logically investigating **double negation** and discovering the absence of independent existence of phenomena, this by itself does not put an end to suffering.

According to the early ***suttas***, the link at which the chain of dependent origination can be directly broken is ***taṇhā*** (craving):

vedanā → ***taṇhā*** → ***upādāna*** → ***bhava***

Practice is directed not toward the construction of new concepts but toward the ***elimination of the mind's clinging*** to pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral experience.

> *When craving ceases, clinging ceases.*
> *When clinging ceases, becoming ceases.*
> *When becoming ceases, birth does not arise.*

With the cessation of birth, old age and death do not arise, and along with them the entire mass of suffering comes to an end.

> Thus, **ignorance** is eliminated not through the theoretical construction of a correct view but as a ***fruit of the practice*** of non-clinging and the purification of the mind from its defilements.

It is precisely for this reason that in the early texts the Buddha points to the path of practice through the ***cessation of craving***, rather than through the conceptual elimination of all forms of ignorance by means of logical analysis. Were liberation achievable through conceptual understanding alone, the Buddha would have indicated this.

8. Double Negation as the Removal of Extreme Views

The logical elimination of the extremes of existence and non-existence plays the role of removing **wrong views**. However, it does not by itself eliminate craving and does not put an end to suffering.

Even a correct understanding of the absence of independent existence of phenomena does not lead to liberation without the ***practice of non-clinging***.

Therefore, **double negation** fulfils the function of eliminating erroneous metaphysical views, but the cessation of ***saṃsāra*** is linked to the cessation of ***taṇhā*** (craving).

> Primordial **ignorance** manifests not only as a wrong philosophical view but as the ***habitual tendency*** of the mind to attribute enduring reality to experienced phenomena and to cling to them. More precisely, ignorance is the inability to recognize ***anicca*** (impermanence), ***dukkha*** (unsatisfactoriness), and ***anattā*** (non-self) in directly experienced phenomena. Therefore, the elimination of ignorance is connected not only with correct understanding but above all with ***practice that uproots clinging***.

9. True Perception

TRULY

In the case of true perception, **"there is no non-Being"** neither arises by itself nor produces anything. Since **"non-existence of non-Being"** does not exist, neither does the **"existence of non-Being."** Consequently, there is no **"existence of Being,"** nor can there be **"non-existence of Being."**

> Thus, ***nothing, anywhere, ever, and under any conditions*** (neither from itself, nor from another, nor from both, nor without cause) ***arises or produces anything.***

Mental constructs cease, and with them, associated unwholesome actions of body and speech are not performed. No ***kammic*** imprints are created, becoming does not arise, and birth, old age, and death are not generated.

Because the causes are absent, the result — the "stream of conditioned existence" of a living being (who has realized the **"truth of cessation"**) — as well as the associated suffering of all three types, does not arise anywhere, ever, or under any conditions.

Justification

— One who perceives the **"interdependent existence of phenomena"** on the relative level of existence as a result of their emptiness in the absolute sense sees **Emptiness** (the absolute nature of phenomena).

— One who perceives the emptiness of phenomena on the absolute level of existence as a result of their interdependent relative existence — and who understands that no other type of existence is possible (since all four alternatives of existence are refuted by absolute analysis) — sees both **"interdependent arising"** and **"emptiness."**

— One who perceives **"interdependent arising"** and **"emptiness"** as separate from one another ***sees falsely!*** To perceive them as identical is also ***to see falsely!***

— One who perceives them as both separate and identical at the same time ***sees falsely!*** To perceive a causal relationship between them is likewise ***to see falsely!***

— One who sees that none of the possible alternatives (the four extremes) are satisfactory **does not see anything** — precisely because he does not "see" — and in this **non-seeing** (thus, he perceives nothing false), ***he truly perceives!***

Practice is directed not toward the construction of a new metaphysics but toward the ***cessation of the mind's clinging*** to experienced phenomena. When clinging is absent, the conditions for further becoming do not form.

To avoid clinging to extreme views is to neither generate **"Existence"** nor **"Non-Existence,"** from which all contradictions arise. To uphold right understanding without being affected by any limiting concepts or ideologies, and through the ***practice of non-clinging*** to help oneself and others free themselves from false perceptions — this is the ***true Middle Path.***

Namaste